Arab Consortium for Teaching and Learning Centers (ACTLC)

Best Practice in Teaching and Learning

Research-Integrated Teaching: Bridging Scholarship, Leadership Practice, and Student Research

Faculty Biography

Dr. Amal Ahmadi is an Associate Professor at the American University of Bahrain (AUBH) and a Fellow of the Higher Education Academy (FHEA), with over 15 years of international experience in higher education and industry. Her teaching and research interests span leadership development, management, entrepreneurship, and workplace emotions. Her doctoral research explored the leadership knowing-doing gap, examining how fear influences the translation of leadership knowledge into action. Dr. Ahmadi actively integrates her scholarship into teaching, student supervision, and professional development initiatives to bridge academic knowledge and organizational practice.

Course Context

MGMT 513 Leadership Development and Team Building is a graduate-level course delivered as part of the Master of Business Administration (MBA) program at AUBH. The course develops students' understanding of contemporary leadership theories and practices while encouraging critical reflection on their own leadership experiences and professional contexts. Through research-informed discussions, experiential learning, and reflective activities, students are encouraged to move beyond theoretical understanding and explore how leadership knowledge can be translated into effective practice. The course provides an opportunity to integrate faculty research into the learning experience, particularly given the diverse professional backgrounds and experiences that MBA students bring to the classroom.

Best Practice Initiative: Integrating Faculty Research into Teaching and Learning

A key example of research-integrated teaching within MGMT 513 is a dedicated session on "The Leadership Knowing-Doing Gap and the Role of Fear and Courage," which draws directly on Dr. Ahmadi's doctoral research and subsequent peer-reviewed publication in the Academy of Management Learning & Education journal (Ahmadi, A. and Vogel, B. (2023) Knowing but not enacting leadership: Navigating the leadership knowing-doing gap in leveraging leadership development, Academy of Management Learning and Education, 22(3): 507- 530).

Students engage with the published research as an assigned reading and critically connect its theoretical insights with leadership challenges encountered in their own professional contexts. This approach bridges research, theory, and practice, encouraging students to reflect on the factors that prevent leaders from translating what they know into what they do.

The learning experience is further enriched through supplementary multimedia material, including Dr. Ahmadi's interview on Phronesis, the official podcast of the International Leadership Association (ILA) (https://go.ivoox.com/rf/154802953 / Phronesis - International Leadership Association). The podcast interview translates the research into practical insights and actionable recommendations for leaders, providing students with an accessible, practice-oriented complement to the academic publication.

Impact on Student Learning and Research

The relevance of this research-integrated teaching initiative is reflected in student course evaluation feedback, with one student specifically highlighting the knowing-doing gap session:

"… Particularly, the last session we had which talks about the Knowing-Doing Gap leadership, it was very useful and insightful."

More significantly, student engagement with the topic has extended beyond the classroom, inspiring further academic inquiry and application within distinct professional contexts. Two MBA students are currently undertaking theses under Dr. Ahmadi's supervision that build on the leadership knowing-doing gap research. One examines its application to Health, Safety, and Environment (HSE) practices in Bahrain's oil and gas sector. The other explores the knowing-doing gap within the strategic leadership of boards across institutions in Bahrain. These ongoing research projects demonstrate how faculty scholarship can stimulate student inquiry and encourage the application of theoretical knowledge to new organizational and sectoral contexts.

Overall, this initiative illustrates a progression from faculty research and scholarly dissemination to classroom learning, professional application, and student-led research. It demonstrates how research-integrated teaching can foster critical inquiry, strengthen the connection between academic knowledge and professional practice, and inspire students to contribute to the development of new knowledge.